things are hard to hide—what if they are detected?" he asked Khrushchev. There was no satisfactory answer.[3]

Still, on May 21, Khrushchev's argument carried the day. With the rest of the leadership either silent or expressing support for Khrushchev's proposal, he was able to brush off Mikoyan's dissent with little difficulty. Mikoyan remained in the minority, recalling later that he was the only one who opposed Khrushchev on the issue. The Defense Council, whose meeting doubled as a meeting of the Presidium, decided to authorize preparations for placing nuclear-armed missiles in Cuba. The terse notes on specific measures discussed and approved by the leadership read as follows: "Install nuclear rocket weapons. Transport them secretly. Disclose later. Rockets under our command. This will be an offensive policy." Those present also decided to initiate talks with Castro about signing a mutual defense treaty.[4]

Ever since he crushed the old-guard opposition to his rule in the summer of 1957 and made himself head of both party and government in the spring of 1958, Khrushchev had had little if any opposition to his leadership of the party and the state. Mikoyan, who had begun his party career under Lenin and survived Stalin, was the only old-timer in government still in a position to ask Khrushchev questions and contradict him in open discussion. The rest were Khrushchev's appointees who, like Andrei Gromyko, preferred not to voice their thoughts and, in particular, their criticism of Khrushchev's ideas and increasingly adventurous behavior at home and abroad. One-man rule gave Khrushchev enormous latitude to be quick, decisive, and flexible in crisis situations, but it also gave him opportunities to create crises at will. One could only hope that he would be as good at resolving such crises as he was at creating them.

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KHRUSHCHEV CHARGED THE MINISTER OF DEFENSE, MARSHAL Rodion Malinovsky, and the commander in chief of the Strategic Missile Forces, Marshal Biriuzov, with assessing the scope and time frame of the operation required to deliver the missiles and nuclear warheads to Cuba.